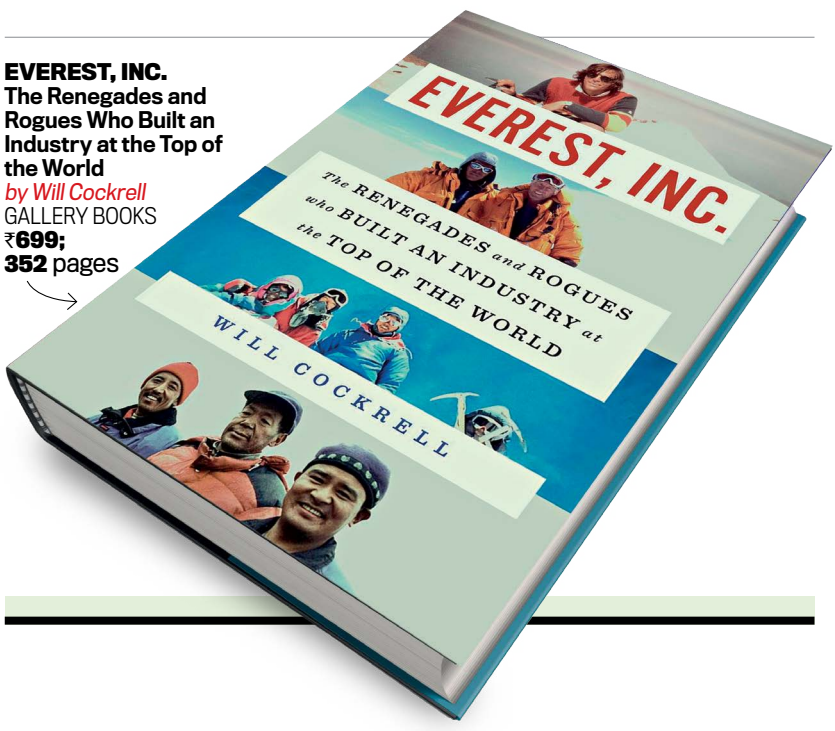
BOOKS

CLIMB EVERY MOUNTAIN

Everest, Inc. is about the aura of the world's tallest mountain and the commercial climbing industry it has spawned

EVEREST, INC.
The Renegades and Rogues Who Built an Industry at the Top of the World
by Will Cockrell
GALLERY BOOKS
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352 pages



There are 14 mountains in the world that stand above 8,000 metres. Only a few of us are likely to rattle off all their names. Most won't go beyond a handful, but almost everyone will name the highest of them all, Mount Everest. A lot remains the same when it comes to the climbing aspirations of the majority today. This, at a time when there is ambiguity over the very definition of mountaineering. Here's why.

There was a time when climbers would stand at the base of a mountain and gaze at it objectively to figure out a feasible route to the summit. These days, behemoths like Everest are roped from bottom to top by high-altitude guides. There's every facility available at a price. And it's accessible for anyone who harbours the dream of standing at the highest point in the world. Welcome to the world of commercial climbing that is at the heart of *Everest Inc.*, American journalist Will Cockrell's first book.

In climbing history, few narratives hold as much prominence as the race for Everest. Even once it ended in 1953, when Edmund Hillary and Tenzing Norgay stood on the summit, others searched for challenges that would give them a place in mountaineering history. Some attempted new routes; others climbed without supplementary oxygen.

Sometime in the early 1980s, a few mountaineers with the entrepreneurial spirit got thinking. Guiding had been a known profession on smaller mountains, from the Alps to the Andes. What if they took it to the Himalayas?

The question arose with the prospect of climbing the seven highest mountains on each continent. During the early days, most steered clear of Everest. But as the logistics were figured out, the race was back on—this time around, to get the first paying client on the summit of Everest.

By 1992, the floodgates had opened. From 17 expeditions that spring, the number climbed to 45 in a decade. But the explosion of commercial climbing was a phenomenon only seen on Everest. For instance, the third highest mountain, Kangchenjunga, still had just four teams in 2002.

In between that period was the 1996 climbing disaster when Everest recorded 11 deaths. A few thought it would be a deterrent for inexperienced climbers, but it only increased the popularity of the mountain. There was still the uncertainty of making it to the top, the question of life and death, and the thrill of taking on a formidable challenge. Just that now, there was someone watching your back every step of the way. And yes, anyone with the money could go.

It's no different today. Come March, a civilisation inhabits Everest Base Camp for the next few weeks. There's a rate card for everything from the supply of oxygen available to the number of helping hands while climbing. And with every successful summit comes the tag of 'Everester', and the many laurels and bragging rights that follow.

The business of Everest-climbing and its evolution makes this an engaging read, as the book sheds light on the many characters and incidents that have shaped the industry over the years. It will make it evident why the demand for Everest is here to stay. ■

–Shail Desai